

[Return to Search](#)

The Maasai of Matapato

Author(S): Spencer, Paul

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 110

Culture (OWC): [Maasai \(FL12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: July 1976-September 1977

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Matapato, Kenya

Section Title(S)

THE MANYATA VILLAGE AND THE ELDERS' VILLAGE AREAS

Lifting milk is quite different from stealing. Any boys taking milk in this way would be punished as unprincipled thieves. Again, since moran have to share milk together, if one is seen entering a young wife's hut by himself, then this could not be to 'lift' milk, but only to 'steal' her. The watching elders will converge on the hut to catch him. Few moran would take such risks during the daytime.

- 272
[Nonalcoholic Beverages](#)
- 425
[Changes In Property Rights](#)
- 561
[Age Stratification](#)
- 574
[Visiting And Hospitality](#)
- 685
[Property Offenses](#)
- 701
[Military Organization](#)

The elders face a dilemma. They cannot stop moran exercising their privilege of 'lifting' milk, but this encourages them to assume a privilege to 'steal' wives. The elders wish to avoid the moran but still harbour suspicions when a body of moran enter the hut of the young wife of an absent elder, no matter how brief their visit. They have stories of their own moranhood when perhaps five of them entered a hut together and emerged gratified in every sense in as

- 561
[Age Stratification](#)
- 701
[Military Organization](#)
- 837

little time as it would have taken to drink all the milk. The elders can only demand that visiting moran should behave as guests with an outward respect, and the moran are aware that their comings and goings are being carefully watched from a discreet distance.

Extramarital Sex
Relations

It is this concern with adultery that places the manyata in a contemporary setting. The decreasing relevance of its defensive role is compensated by the advantages of segregating moran from the younger wives of elders. This is possibly one of the principal reasons why the manyata system has survived attempts to abolish it by successive administrations and the threats and assertions of elders. The dilemma facing the elders is that while all moran should ideally be at the manyata and away from their village areas, they can only fulfil their defensive role by visiting all areas. Even the non-manyata moran play their part in protecting the herds. When an elder suspects that his wives have regular liaisons with lovers and especially with moran living in the area, then this is the time to migrate - but where? A more isolated spot is by definition less guarded by other elders; while a more populated area also attracts more moran.

561
Age Stratification

701
Military Organization

837
Extramarital Sex
Relations

The elders' attitude towards adultery is at least reinforced in the ideology  111 of the manyata. If a manyata moran stays in the elders' village area for more than the occasional night without manyata permission, he must account for himself on his return. Even if he has permission and a good reason - say to help his father with his herd during a difficult period - he can expect to be teased. His absence is made to imply that he has been malingering with young wives and is already fading into the habits of elderhood. When other manyata moran see him returning, they may call out: 'The donkeys have come.' The manyata women then take up the joke: 'He's just a donkey, for he ran away to the elders' villages ... Let's grab him and drive him to get some water! Let's put a hide on his back and load him up!' The insinuation is that

561
Age Stratification

701
Military Organization

837
Extramarital Sex
Relations

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)